

Monica Cholico

Creative Developer & Visual Storyteller

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May 13, 2026

Dear Simone Landon,

I want to be upfront: my path to visual storytelling hasn't been a conventional one. I don't come from a newsroom background. But I've spent the past several years building the kind of work the Graphics department produces — interactive, data-driven visual stories designed to help people understand issues that I'm curious about — and I'm writing because I believe my trajectory, my technical skills, and my curiosity make me a strong candidate for this role.

The clearest example of my work is Planeta Mujer (planeta-mujer.org), an interactive data visualization platform I designed and coded from scratch. "50 Million" is a scroll-driven narrative on modern slavery that animates 10,000 Canvas particles into country shapes through D3 force simulation, contextualizing 50 million victims against national populations and historical atrocities. I also built an interactive world map of World Bank gender equality scores across 190 countries, an SVG hourglass comparing gendered time use across 30 OECD nations, and an interactive sunburst taxonomy of feminist thought. Each project began with data I sourced, cleaned, and analyzed — and a question: how do I make this visual, clear, and hard to look away from?

The platform grew out of my master's work in gender and social policy. In 2011, I founded Planeta Mujer to translate complex policy research into accessible content for a Spanish-speaking audience. Last year, I rebuilt it as a data visualization platform because I realized that the stories I wanted to tell needed to be seen, not just read. That same instinct led me to write over 140 bilingual explanatory articles for Feel Like Dancing, a ballet publication I've run since 2014 — where I discovered that I could share information I'm knowledgeable and passionate about in a way that engages and informs readers.

For the past almost five years, I've been a front-end engineer at the Times, building interactive applications on the advertising side. I work daily in JavaScript, HTML, CSS, and modern frameworks, and I collaborate closely with designers and editorial partners. I'm proficient in Adobe Creative Suite and Figma. I've also been investing in my editorial foundations: I'm currently completing NYU's Modern Journalism certificate and a diplomado in digital experiences and ecosystems. I know I have more to learn on the reporting side — and I'm actively working to close that gap.

What I'd bring to the Graphics department is a combination of strong technical skills (D3.js, Canvas API, SVG, Scrollama, Python, R), a deep personal commitment to the kind of stories this desk tells, bilingual fluency in English and Spanish, and an investigative mindset shaped by my years as a fraud investigator at the U.S. Embassy in Mexico City — where finding patterns in data and making complex systems legible was the daily work. I'm curious, I'm driven, and I'm building toward this kind of journalism with everything I do outside of my current role. I would welcome the opportunity to do it here.

Sincerely,

Monica Cholico